Horton Hears a Who

By Theo Geisel (aka Dr. Seuss)

On the fifteenth of May in the jungle of Nool
In the heat of the day, in the cool of the pool
He was splashing… enjoying the jungle's great joys
When Horton the elephant heard a small noise.

INTRODUCTION

Theodore Seuss Geisel was born in Springfield Massachusetts in 1904. His mother would often help him go to sleep by chanting rhymes. This combined with an enchanted walk through Springfield's Forest Park, inspired this young author to write a creative tale about an elephant who courageously protects and defends a speck of dust that is inhabited by a very small society of "people." Please enjoy this rendition of "Horton Hears a Who" by Theodore Geisel (aka Dr. Seuss).

So Horton stopped splashing. He looked toward the sound.
"That's funny," thought Horton. "There's no one around."
Then he heard it again! Just a very faint yelp. (make a sound)
As if some tiny person were calling for help.
"I'll help you," said Horton. "But who are you? Where?"
He looked and he looked. He could see nothing there

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But a small speck of dust blowing past through the air.
"I say!" murmured Horton. "I've never heard tell
Of a small speck of dust that is able to yell.
So you know what I think?... Why, I think that there must
Be someone on top of that small speck of dust?
"Some poor little person who's shaking with fear
That he'll blow in the pool! He has no way to steer!
I'll just have to save him. Because after all,
A person's a person, no matter how small.
So gently, and using the greatest of care,
The elephant stretched his great trunk through the air,
And lifted the dust speck and carried it over
And placed it down, safe, on a very soft clover.
"Humpf" humpfed a voice. "Twas a sour Kangaroo.
And the young kangaroo in her pouch said "Humpf!" too
"Why, that speck is as small as the head of a pin.
A person on That? Why there never has been"
"Believe Me," said Horton, "I tell you sincerely.
My ears are quite keen and I heard you quite clearly.
I know there's a person down there. And what's more.
Quite likely there's two, Event three, Even Four.
"I think you're a fool laughed the sour Kangaroo
And the young kangaroo in her pouch said, "Me too!"
And the Kangaroo plunged in the cool of the pool.

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“What terrible splashing!” the elephant frowned.
“I can’t let my very small persons get drowned.
I’ve got to protect them. I’m bigger than they.”
So he plucked up the clover and hustled away.
Through the high jungle tree tops, the news quickly spread:
“He talks to a dust speck! He’s out of his head!”
“Should I put this speck down? Horton thought with alarm.
“If I do, these small persons may come to great harm.
I can’t put it down, And I won’t! After all
A person’s a person. No matter how small.
Then Horton stopped walking. The speck-voice was talking
The voice was so faint he could just barely hear it.
“Speak up, please,” said Horton. He put his ear near it.
“I know,” called the voice, “I’m too small to be seen
But I’m Mayor of a town that is friendly and clean.
My town is called Who-ville, for I am a who
And we Who’s are all thankful and grateful to you”
And Horton called back to the Mayor of the town,
“You’re safe now. Don’t worry. I won’t let you down.”
But just as he spoke to the Mayor of the speck
Three big jungle monkeys climbed up Horton’s neck.
The Wickersham Brothers came shouting, “What Rot”
This elephants talking to Who’s who are not
There aren’t any Whos, And they don’t have a Mayor

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And we’re going to stop all this nonsense! So there!”
They snatched Horton’s clover! They carried it off
To a black- bottomed eagle named Vlad Vlad-i-Koff,
And, before the poor elephant could even speak,
That eagle flew off with the flower in his beak.
While Horton chased aftr, with groans, over stones
That tattered his toenails and battered his bones,
And begged, “Please don’t harm all my little folks, who
Have as much right to live as us bigger folk do!”
But far, far beyond him, that eagle kept flapping
And over his shoulder called back “Quit your yapping.
I’ll fly the night through. I’m a bird. I don’t mind it.
And I’ll hide this, tomorrow, where you’ll never find it!”
And at 6:56 the next morning he did it.
It sure was a terrible place that he hid it.
He let that small clover drop somewhere inside
Of a great patch of clovers a hundred miles wide!
“Find That!” sneered the bird. “But I think you will fail.”
And he left, with a flip, of his black bottomed tail.
“I’ll find it!” cried Horton. “I’ll find it or bust!”
I shall find my friends on my small speck of dust!”
And clover, by clover, by clover with care.
He picked up and searched them, and called, “Are you there?”
And by noon poor old Horton, more dead than alive,

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Had picked, searched, and piled up, nine thousand and five.
Then , on through the afternoon, hour after hour.
Till he found them at last! On the three millionth flower!
“My friends!” cried the elephant. “Tell me! Do Tell!
Are you safe? Are you sound? Are you whole? Are you well?
From down the speck came the voice of the Mayor:
“We’ve really had trouble! Much more than our share.
When that black-bottom birdie let go and we dropped,
Our tea pots are broken, our clocks have all stopped.
So, Horton, Please” pleaded the voice of the Mayor
“Will you stick by us Whos while we’re making repairs?
“Of course” Horton answered. “Of course I will stick
I’ll stick by you small folks through thin and through thick!”
“Humpf!”
Humpfed a voice!
“For almost two days you’ve run wild and insisted
On chatting with persons who’ve never existed.
And I’m here to state” snapped the big kangaroo,
“That your silly nonsensical game is all through!”
And the young kangaroo in her pouch said, “Me too!”
“With the Wickersham Brother whose help I’ve engaged
You’re going to be roped! And you’re going to be caged!
And, as for your dust speck… hah! That we shall boil
In a hot steaming kettle of Beezle-nut oil!”

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“Boil it?” gasped Horton!” “Oh, that you can’t do!”
It’s all full of persons! They’ll prove it to you!”
And down on the dust speck, the scared little Mayor
Quick called a big meeting in Who-ville Town Square.
And his people cried loudly. They cried out in fear:
“We are here! We are here! We are here! We are here!
The elephant smiled: “That was clear as a bell.
You kangaroos surely heard that very well.”
“I heard no small voice and you didn’t either”
And the young kangaroo in her pouch said, “Me, neither”
Grab him? They shoulted, “and cage the big dope!”
Lasso his stomach with ten miles of rope!
Horton fought back with great vigor and vim
But the Wickersham gang was too many for him.
They beat him! They mauled him! They started to haul
Him into his cage, but he managed to call
To the Mayor, I can hear you just fine
But the kangaroo’s ears aren’t as strong quite as mine.
They don’t hear a thing! Are you sure all your boys
Are doing their best? Are they all making noise?
Through the town rushed the Mayor, From the east to the west.
But everyone seemed to be doing his best,
But it wasn’t enough, all this ruckus and roar!
He had to find someone to help him make more.

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He raced through each building! He searched floor to floor
And just as he felt he was getting nowhere,
And almost about to give up in despair,
He suddenly burst through a door and that Mayor
Discovered one very small shirker named Jo-Jo
Was standing, just standing, and bouncing a yo-yo!
Not making a sound! Not a yipp! Not a chirp!
And the Mayor rushed inside and grabbed the young twerp!
And he climbed with the lad up the Eiffelberg Tower
"This" cried the Mayor "Is your town's darkest hour!"
"We've Got to make noises in greater amounts
So, open your mouth lad! For every voice counts!"
Thus he spoke as he climbed. When he got to the top,
The lad cleared his throat and he shouted out "Yopp!"
And that "Yopp"
That one small, extra Yopp, put it over!
Finally, at last! From that speck on that clover
Their voices were heard! They rang out clear and clean.
And the elephant smiled. "Do you see what I mean?"
They've proved they are persons, no matter how small.
And their whole world was saved by the smallest of all!"

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